

5 Straight-Wall Cartridges, Rated for Corn-Country Whitetail

What actually performs from a treestand at ag-land ranges — not a ballistics-chart argument.

If you hunt anywhere in the Midwest — Ohio for me — your state might have rules about what kind of firearm you can use for deer. With these limited options, you can stick with your shotgun, or you can venture into the world of straight-walled cartridges. This is no small investment, and you only get to use it for a week or two each year. Oh, the pressure! With an investment like this, you're going to want to be prepared — not only is your wallet involved, your entire deer season could be at stake. I've taken and ranked the top 5 straight-wall cartridges available to the Midwest hunter going after those corn-fed bucks.



NO. 1 — BEST ALL-AROUND

.350 Legend

Built from the ground up to satisfy straight-wall regulations rather than adapted to them, and it shows. Recoil is mild enough that a first-season hunter can shoot it well, factory ammo is cheap and everywhere, and it holds enough energy past 150 yards — though trajectory drops off quickly after that. One of the chief complaints I've heard is that the .350 Legend doesn't create much of a blood trail, so if you need to do any tracking, it might be tougher than you'd like. If you're buying your first straight-wall rifle with no other constraints, this is the one to build around.

EFFECTIVE RANGE: ~150-175 YDS | RECOIL: LOW | AMMO COST: LOW | AVAILABILITY: EXCELLENT

NO. 2 — BEST IF YOU WANT MORE KNOCKDOWN

.400 Legend

The newer, harder-hitting sibling to the .350 Legend, using a wider bullet for more energy transfer at the same moderate recoil level. Ammo selection is thinner and prices run higher since it's still catching on, but if a rifle maker already chambers something you like in .400 Legend, it's a legitimate upgrade path over the .350 without stepping into big-bore recoil.

EFFECTIVE RANGE: ~150 YDS | RECOIL: LOW-MODERATE | AMMO COST: MODERATE-HIGH | AVAILABILITY: GROWING

NO. 3 — BEST FOR THICK COVER, HARDER HITS

.450 Bushmaster

Hits noticeably harder than the Legend rounds and is a strong choice if most of your shots come from thick fence-line cover at closer range rather than across an open field. The tradeoff is real: recoil is stout enough to matter for follow-up shots, ammo costs more, and effective range drops off faster past 150 yards than the flatter-shooting Legend cartridges.

EFFECTIVE RANGE: ~150 YDS | RECOIL: MODERATE-HIGH | AMMO COST: MODERATE | AVAILABILITY: GOOD

NO. 4 — BEST IF YOU ALREADY OWN A LEVER GUN

.44 Magnum

The honest pick for anyone who already has a lever-action .44 Mag in the safe and doesn't want to buy a dedicated rifle. It's proven on deer for decades, ammo is easy to find, and recoil is manageable in a rifle-length gun. Its ceiling is lower than the others here — effective range tightens up close to 100 yards, which is fine for tight cover but limiting on open ag ground.

EFFECTIVE RANGE: ~100 YDS | RECOIL: LOW-MODERATE | AMMO COST: MODERATE | AVAILABILITY: GOOD

NO. 5 — BEST FOR CLOSE-RANGE KNOCKDOWN, WORST FOR RECOIL

.45-70 Government

No cartridge on this list hits harder up close, and none is less forgiving to shoot repeatedly. The .45-70 is a fine choice if your stands are all inside thick timber at 75 yards or less and you want maximum authority on a shot, but its rainbow-like trajectory and heavy recoil make it the least versatile pick for anyone hunting mixed ag-edge terrain.

EFFECTIVE RANGE: ~100 YDS | RECOIL: HIGH | AMMO COST: MODERATE-HIGH | AVAILABILITY: GOOD

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Always confirm your specific state's straight-wall cartridge regulations (case length, caliber minimums/maximums, and zone restrictions) before hunting — requirements vary by state and can change. Rankings here reflect typical treestand and ag-edge hunting scenarios inside 150 yards; your rifle, ammo choice, and shot placement matter more than any cartridge on this list.